

Beta-3 Agonists (for Overactive Bladder)

Patient Information · A newer bladder pill with fewer dry-mouth effects

WARWIKI

Beta-3 agonists are a newer group of pills for **overactive bladder**: sudden urges, frequent trips and urge leaks. They relax the bladder so it can hold more. They cause **much less dry mouth and constipation** than the older anticholinergic pills. The two in use are **mirabegron (Myrbetriq)** and **vibegron (Gemtesa)**.

How It Works

They switch on **beta-3 receptors** in the bladder wall. This **relaxes the bladder muscle** as it fills. A calmer bladder means fewer sudden urges and fewer trips. They work in a different way from anticholinergics, and about as well.

What to Expect

- Taken **once a day**. The benefit builds over **about 4–8 weeks**.
- Most people have few side effects and little or no dry mouth.
- Often a good first choice for **older adults**, or for anyone who had side effects from anticholinergics.
- Vibegron is also approved for men who take medicine for an enlarged prostate.
- For stubborn symptoms, it can be combined with an anticholinergic.

Learn the Terms

Overactive bladder (OAB)

Urgency and frequent urination from the bladder squeezing too soon.

Beta-3 agonist

A pill that relaxes the bladder through beta-3 receptors.

Mirabegron and vibegron

The two medicines in this group.

Anticholinergic

The older group of OAB pills, with more dry mouth and memory concerns.

Blood pressure

Mirabegron can raise it a little, so it is checked.

Why choose this over the older pills? Beta-3 agonists work about as well as anticholinergics, with **much less dry mouth and constipation**. They do not add to the “anticholinergic” load linked to memory problems, which is why many teams prefer them for older adults. Long-term studies on memory are still limited. The main thing to watch is blood pressure with mirabegron.

How to Take It

- Take it **once a day** as directed. Give it several weeks to work.
- Keep up bladder training and pelvic floor exercises for the best result.
- Keep your follow-up visits so your team can check the effect and your blood pressure.

Important Safety

- **Mirabegron can raise blood pressure.** It is not used if your blood pressure is very high and not controlled. Vibegron has little effect on blood pressure.
- Tell your team about all your medicines, especially **digoxin** or heart rhythm medicines. Some levels may need checking.
- Tell your team if you have **kidney or liver disease**, or trouble emptying your bladder.

Common Side Effects

- Usually mild: headache, stuffy nose
- Urine infection
- A rise in blood pressure (mainly mirabegron)

Call the office that is treating you if you have:

- Blood pressure much higher than usual, or a bad headache
- A weak stream, or you feel you are not emptying

Go to an emergency department if:

- Your face, lips, tongue or throat swell, or you have trouble breathing
- You cannot urinate for several hours and your bladder feels full or painful
- You cannot reach the office and are worried

Three Things to Remember

1. Beta-3 agonists relax the bladder, with far less dry mouth than the older pills.
2. They are often a good fit for older adults. Give them several weeks.
3. Mirabegron can raise blood pressure, so keep your check-ups.